reach. The pick-up vans had images of Modi plastered all over them and the television set would play sixteen-minute videos of Modi's best speeches. Every day, the vans would touch fifteen to twenty villages, almost like a modern-day *jatra* enacting a slice of political theatre. Says the Modi aide, 'Our aim was to create excitement in the village around the theme *"Modi aanewala hai!"'* (Modi is coming.) (See chapter 5 for more.)

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When the results of the assembly elections streamed through on 8 December 2013, the Modi campaign team was delighted. The victories in Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh had run according to script. In Delhi, the BJP had emerged as the single largest party but a hung assembly had been thrown up. In Rajasthan, however, there was real reason to celebrate—not only had the BJP won, it had scored a historic three-fourths triumph. It had won a record 162 seats, with the Congress down to just twenty-one. Importantly, it had swept rural Rajasthan. Rajasthan, interestingly, was a state where the Congress and the Gandhi family had also invested heavily. Many of the party's pet social sector programmes—be it NREGA or a free medicine scheme—had been incubated there. Moditva versus Sonianomics—Rajasthan settled that debate conclusively. It also extinguished any whispers within the Advani–Sushma camp in the BJP that Modi was the wrong choice for prime minister. The anger against the Gehlot government in Rajasthan was palpable, but no one had expected such a tidal wave. The one state where Modi had campaigned most aggressively had yielded the most spectacular result.

'I think the scale of that win told us that we were onto something unique. This was a wave election in Rajasthan. If we could replicate the formula in other major states, Mission 272-plus was not a pipe dream,' is how a Modi team member summed up the post-Rajasthan feeling.

Mission 272-plus had been calculated keeping in mind that the BJP did not have an all-India base like the Congress but was largely focused on north, west and central India. 'A north-west monsoon seems to be building